

PSY405 - Lesson 19

Humanistic view in psychology

Humanistic psychology focuses on the **good side of people, free choice**, and **personal growth**. It says people are not only shaped by past events or environment, they also **choose** who they become.

Meaning of key terms

- **Humanistic psychology**

A branch of psychology that believes humans are basically good, capable of growth, and able to make free choices.

- **Abnormality**

In psychology, this means **unhealthy or unusual behavior** such as severe anxiety, depression or aggressive behavior.

How humanistic psychology explains abnormal behavior

It says abnormal behavior happens when someone **does not accept responsibility** for their actions and thoughts.

Example

A person keeps failing exams but always blames teachers or bad luck. Humanistic psychology would say the person should accept responsibility, study better, plan better, and grow.

Humanistic psychologists also believe:

- human nature is **basically good**
- society sometimes pushes people toward aggression or unhealthy behavior

Example

A child is kind by nature but grows up in a violent neighborhood. Humanists say the **environment** caused aggression, not the child's inner nature.

Is Maslow a humanistic psychologist?

Yes, **Abraham Maslow** is one of the most famous humanistic psychologists.

Maslow's hierarchy of needs

Maslow said humans have **levels of needs**. The lower needs must be met before higher needs.

The order is:

1. Physiological needs
2. Safety needs
3. Love and belongingness
4. Self esteem
5. Self actualization

This is usually shown like a pyramid. Many people stay at lower levels, only a few reach the top.

Meaning of psychological term: Hierarchy of needs

This means needs are arranged from **most basic to highest level**.

1. Physiological needs

Meaning

Basic physical needs needed to stay alive.

Examples

- food
- water
- sleep
- oxygen
- protection from extreme heat or cold

A hungry person thinks mainly about food, not poetry or philosophy.

2. Safety needs

Meaning

Need to feel **safe, secure and protected**.

Examples

- safe home
- job security
- health security
- predictable environment

Children show this strongly. A baby cries when dropped suddenly or hears a loud noise because it feels unsafe.

3. Love and belongingness needs

Meaning

Need to feel connected to others and not lonely.

Examples

- friends
- family love
- being accepted by classmates
- feeling part of a group

A student far from home feels homesick because belongingness needs are not satisfied.

4. Self esteem needs

Meaning

Need to feel **capable and respected**.

Maslow divided it into two types.

- **self respect**

feeling confident, capable, independent

- **esteem from others**

getting recognition, appreciation, status

Examples

- winning a prize
 - being praised by teachers
 - feeling you are good at your work
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5. Self actualization

Meaning

Reaching your **full potential** in life. Becoming what you are capable of becoming.

Examples

- a musician creating great music
- a scientist doing great research
- an athlete reaching world level

People like **Quaid e Azam, Dr Abdul Salam, Javed Miandad** are examples often used.

Self actualization gives fulfillment but also brings fear of big responsibility.

Why do very few people reach self actualization?

Maslow said:

- people often **do not see their own abilities**
- many **fear their potential**
- society sometimes **blocks growth**

Only a very small percent reach the highest level.

Maslow's meta motivational theory

Meaning of term: Meta needs

Meta means **beyond** basic needs. These are higher values of life.

Basic needs include:

- hunger
- thirst
- safety
- love
- self esteem

Meta needs include:

- justice
- beauty
- goodness
- order

When meta needs are not met, people also feel mentally unwell.

Basic concepts of humanistic psychology

1. Individual as an integrated whole

Humanistic psychology says a person must be studied as a **whole person**, not in small parts.

Behaviorism studied small bits of behavior, humanists disagreed.

Example

Instead of only studying memory or fear, humanists study full personality, goals, emotions, relationships.

2. Irrelevance of animal research

Humanists believe **studying animals is not enough** to understand humans.

Humans are unique because they:

- think about meaning of life
- ask "Who am I?"

- plan their future

Animals do not write personality theories.

3. Man's inner nature

Freud said humans have **unconscious aggressive and sexual impulses** that can be destructive. Humanists disagree.

Humanists say:

- people are basically good
- bad behavior comes from **bad environment**

Example

Violence grows in war zones, not because humans are born evil.

4. Human creative potential

Creativity is not only painting or music. Everyone can be creative in daily life.

Examples

- creative teacher
- creative homemaker
- creative business owner
- creative student finding new study methods

Creativity is seen as natural in all humans.

5. Emphasis on psychological health

Humanistic psychology focuses on **healthy people**, not just mental illness.

It criticizes Freud for focusing mainly on **neurotic or psychotic disorders**.

They study:

- happiness
- meaning of life
- personal growth

What are self actualizers like?

Maslow listed around sixteen characteristics such as:

- reality based thinking
- creativity
- acceptance of self and others
- independence
- deep relationships
- sense of humor

They are **not perfect or angelic**, they still make mistakes.

Goal of psychotherapy in humanistic psychology

The goal is:

- help the person **grow**
- help them accept responsibility
- help discover real self
- help reach potential

The focus is not only on removing symptoms, but on **personal development**.

Short biography of Maslow

- born in 1908 in Brooklyn
- parents were poor immigrants from Russia
- studied psychology in Wisconsin
- first influenced by behaviorism
- changed views after observing his own children
- became leader of humanistic psychology

- wrote important books like *Motivation and Personality* and *Toward a Psychology of Being*
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Quick summary

Humanistic psychology believes people are:

- basically good
- able to choose
- able to grow

Maslow said people have different levels of needs. First we fulfill basic needs like food and safety, then love and respect, and finally we try to become the **best version of ourselves**.

SHORT QUESTIONS

1. Question: What is humanistic psychology?

Answer:

Humanistic psychology is a branch of psychology that focuses on the **positive aspects of human life**, such as growth, personal freedom, and the ability to make choices. It assumes that humans are **basically good**, and abnormal behavior results from the **failure to take responsibility for one's own actions and thoughts**.

Explanation:

Humanistic psychology differs from other approaches like behaviorism or psychoanalysis because it focuses on **healthy human development** instead of illness or animal behavior. It emphasizes that humans have the **power to shape their own lives** through choices.

Example:

A student who fails an exam might blame others or give excuses. A humanistic approach would encourage the student to **accept responsibility**, learn from mistakes, and plan better next time.

Tips:

Think of humanistic psychology as a “growth mindset” for the whole person. It values freedom, creativity, and personal meaning.

2. Question: How does humanistic psychology explain abnormal behavior?

Answer:

Humanistic psychology explains abnormal behavior as a result of a **person’s refusal to take responsibility** for their thoughts and actions. It also considers that **negative social environments** can encourage aggression or unhealthy behaviors, but the person’s nature is not inherently bad.

Explanation:

Unlike Freud, who said people have hidden destructive impulses, humanists say people are naturally good, and problems arise when they **avoid responsibility** or are influenced by harmful environments.

Example:

A child growing up in a violent neighborhood might act aggressively. Humanistic psychology says this is due to the environment, not because the child is “evil by nature.”

Tips:

Always link abnormal behavior to **choices and environment**, not to an evil inner nature.

3. Question: Who is Abraham Maslow and why is he important in humanistic psychology?

Answer:

Abraham Maslow (1908–1970) was a humanistic psychologist who developed the **Hierarchy of Needs**, a theory explaining that humans have **different levels of needs**, starting from basic survival and leading up to self-actualization. He focused on **personal growth and motivation** rather than mental illness.

Explanation:

Maslow is important because he shifted the focus of psychology to **healthy human potential**. He studied how people achieve their goals and reach their fullest capabilities.

Example:

Maslow studied real-life figures like **Quaid-e-Azam and Dr. Abdul Salam**, who fulfilled their potential despite challenges.

Tips:

Remember Maslow = "needs + growth + human potential."

4. Question: What is the hierarchy of needs?

Answer:

The hierarchy of needs is a **pyramid of human motivations**. It starts with **basic physiological needs**, then **safety, love and belonging, self-esteem**, and finally **self-actualization**. Maslow said **lower needs must be satisfied first** before higher needs become motivating.

Explanation:

Humans first focus on survival (food, water, shelter). Once survival is secure, they want safety, relationships, respect, and eventually personal fulfillment.

Example:

A person who is starving will care only about food, not relationships or personal growth. Once food is secure, they can focus on friendship, love, or career goals.

Tips:

Visualize a pyramid: the broad base = basic needs, narrow top = self-actualization.

5. Question: What are physiological needs?

Answer:

Physiological needs are **basic physical requirements for survival**, such as food, water, air, sleep, sex, and protection from extreme temperatures.

Explanation:

These needs are **most powerful** because humans cannot live without them. Higher-level needs cannot motivate a person until these are met.

Example:

If someone is very hungry or thirsty, they cannot focus on friendship or study.

Tips:

Always remember: **body first, mind second**.

6. Question: What are safety needs?

Answer:

Safety needs are the desire for **security, stability, and protection from harm**. Once physiological needs are met, people seek safety in their environment, health, and personal life.

Explanation:

Humans naturally avoid danger and want **predictable conditions**. Safety needs are strongest in infants and children but continue into adulthood.

Example:

A child with a broken leg needs protection and reassurance. Adults want safe jobs, secure homes, and health insurance.

Tips:

Think: "Safety first after survival."

7. Question: What are belongingness and love needs?

Answer:

Belongingness and love needs are the desire for **social connection, friendship, and affectionate relationships**. Humans want to feel part of a family, group, or community.

Explanation:

Once basic survival and safety are met, people focus on relationships. Loneliness can make a person feel unhappy or anxious.

Example:

A college student away from home may feel lonely and try hard to make friends.

Tips:

Remember: humans are social creatures.

8. Question: What are self-esteem needs?

Answer:

Self-esteem needs are the desire to **feel competent, confident, and valued** by oneself and others. Maslow divided them into **self-respect** (personal confidence, independence) and **esteem from others** (recognition, appreciation, status).

Explanation:

People need to know they can **handle life challenges** and that their abilities are recognized by society.

Example:

A student working hard to get good grades seeks **self-respect** (personal achievement) and **esteem from others** (teacher praise, awards).

Tips:

Think: "I want to feel capable and respected."

9. Question: What is self-actualization?

Answer:

Self-actualization is the **highest level of human needs**, where a person seeks to **reach their full potential** in all areas of life. It involves personal growth, creativity, and fulfillment.

Explanation:

This is when people strive to **become the best version of themselves**. It is rare; Maslow said only a few people achieve it.

Example:

A musician creating meaningful music, a scientist discovering a new theory, or an athlete reaching world-class level.

Tips:

Remember: self-actualization = **personal peak potential**.

10. Question: Why can't all people achieve self-actualization?

Answer:

Most people cannot reach self-actualization because:

1. They **don't know their potential**
2. They **fear their abilities**
3. Society may **limit growth**

Maslow estimated that less than 1% of people fully achieve it.

Explanation:

Even though the desire to grow is natural, obstacles such as **lack of opportunity**, **self-doubt**, or **unhelpful environments** prevent most people from fully developing.

Example:

A talented student may not pursue their dream career because of poverty, fear of failure, or family pressure.

Tips:

Think: reaching self-actualization is rare but a **life-long process**.

11. Question: What are meta-needs according to Maslow?

Answer:

Meta-needs are **higher-level values beyond basic survival**, such as justice, beauty, goodness, and order. They are different from basic needs, which include hunger, safety, and love.

Explanation:

Meta-needs guide a person toward **spiritual, moral, or aesthetic fulfillment**. Failing to satisfy meta-needs can cause psychological discomfort.

Example:

A person may feel distressed if treated unfairly (justice) or if life feels chaotic (order).

Tips:

Remember: meta-needs = **meaningful human values**.

12. Question: What are the basic concepts of humanistic psychology?

Answer:

1. **The individual as an integrated whole** – study people as a full, unique person.
2. **Irrelevance of animal research** – humans are unique, not just like animals.
3. **Man's inner nature** – humans are basically good, not evil.
4. **Human creative potential** – everyone can be creative, not just artists.
5. **Emphasis on psychological health** – study healthy people, not only mental illness.

Explanation:

Humanistic psychology looks at the **whole person, their growth, creativity, and potential**, instead of just studying disease or isolated behavior.

Example:

Instead of only studying students who fail, humanists study students who succeed and grow, to see what makes people thrive.

Tips:

Think of this as **"positive psychology"** before it was called that.

13. Question: What is the goal of humanistic psychotherapy?

Answer:

The goal is to help a person **grow, accept responsibility, discover their true self, and reach their full potential**. The focus is on **personal development**, not just fixing symptoms.

Explanation:

Unlike traditional therapy that mainly treats illness, humanistic therapy encourages **self-awareness, self-expression, and life meaning**.

Example:

A therapist may guide a client to recognize their strengths, make life choices freely, and pursue passions.

Tips:

Think: therapy = **unlocking potential**, not only curing problems.

1. True/False MCQs

Q1: Humanistic psychology assumes that humans are basically good.

- A)** True
- B)** False

Answer: A – True

Explanation: Humanistic psychology focuses on the positive aspects of humans, believing that people are naturally inclined toward growth and goodness.

Q2: According to Maslow, self-actualization is the first need humans try to satisfy.

- A)** True
- B)** False

Answer: B – False

Explanation: Self-actualization is the **highest-level need**, and basic needs (physiological and safety) must be satisfied first.

Q3: Humanistic psychologists consider animal research as largely irrelevant for understanding human behavior.

A) True

B) False

Answer: A – True

Explanation: Humans are unique in self-awareness, creativity, and the ability to theorize about themselves, so humanistic psychology studies humans directly.

Q4: Humanistic psychotherapy mainly focuses on curing mental illness rather than personal growth.

A) True

B) False

Answer: B – False

Explanation: Humanistic psychotherapy emphasizes **personal development**, self-discovery, and growth rather than just symptom removal.

2. Conceptual MCQs

Q5: Which of the following best describes abnormal behavior according to humanistic psychology?

A) It is caused by unconscious aggressive impulses.

B) It arises from failure to take responsibility for one's actions.

C) It is a result of genetic defects.

D) It is completely determined by past experiences.

Answer: B

Explanation: Humanistic psychology believes abnormal behavior occurs when individuals **avoid responsibility** for their thoughts and actions.

Q6: Which need is considered the most basic in Maslow's hierarchy?

- A) Self-esteem
- B) Love and belongingness
- C) Safety
- D) Physiological needs

Answer: D – Physiological needs

Explanation: Physiological needs (food, water, sleep, oxygen) are the foundation of Maslow's hierarchy because they are necessary for survival.

Q7: According to Maslow, meta-needs include:

- A) Food and water
- B) Security and safety
- C) Justice, beauty, and goodness
- D) Love and belonging

Answer: C – Justice, beauty, and goodness

Explanation: Meta-needs are **higher-level values** that guide humans beyond basic survival and social needs.

Q8: Maslow divided self-esteem needs into:

- A) Physical and social
- B) Basic and meta-needs
- C) Self-respect and esteem from others
- D) Safety and belonging

Answer: C – Self-respect and esteem from others

Explanation: Self-esteem includes internal confidence (self-respect) and external recognition (esteem from others).

Q9: Humanistic psychology was primarily a reaction against which psychological approach?

- A) Cognitive psychology
- B) Behaviorism

- C) Evolutionary psychology
- D) Psychoanalysis

Answer: B – Behaviorism

Explanation: Maslow and humanists criticized behaviorism for **studying only isolated behaviors** instead of the whole person.

3. Situational MCQs

Q10: Ali is an adult who has enough food, a stable job, and a safe home, but feels lonely and rejected. According to Maslow, which need is motivating him?

- A) Physiological
- B) Safety
- C) Love and belongingness
- D) Self-actualization

Answer: C – Love and belongingness

Explanation: Once basic survival and safety are met, people are motivated by **relationships, friendships, and connection.**

Q11: Sara is a talented artist who creates unique paintings despite facing social criticism and financial difficulties. According to Maslow, she is striving toward:

- A) Safety needs
- B) Self-esteem
- C) Self-actualization
- D) Physiological needs

Answer: C – Self-actualization

Explanation: Self-actualization involves **reaching full potential** and pursuing meaningful creative or personal goals even under challenges.

Q12: A student constantly blames teachers for poor grades, avoids studying, and refuses to take responsibility for improvement. Which humanistic concept is most relevant here?

- A) Self-actualization
- B) Refusal to accept personal responsibility
- C) Meta-needs
- D) Safety needs

Answer: B – Refusal to accept personal responsibility

Explanation: Humanistic psychology views **avoiding responsibility** as a key cause of abnormal behavior.

Q13: During therapy, a psychologist encourages a client to explore their strengths, make independent choices, and pursue personal goals. The main goal of this therapy is:

- A) To eliminate anxiety
- B) To treat depression
- C) To achieve personal growth and self-actualization
- D) To control impulses

Answer: C – To achieve personal growth and self-actualization

Explanation: Humanistic therapy focuses on **growth, self-awareness, and fulfilling potential**, not only symptom removal.

Q14 (Tricky): Which statement best aligns with Maslow's view?

- A) All people naturally achieve self-actualization if they survive childhood.
- B) Most people fail to reach self-actualization due to fear, ignorance, or social constraints.
- C) Self-actualization is only possible for people with wealth and education.
- D) Self-actualization is not influenced by environment or society.

Answer: B

Explanation: Maslow estimated **less than 1% of people** fully achieve self-actualization due to personal and social limitations.

Q15 (Tricky True/False): Maslow believed that a person can be motivated by higher-order needs even if basic needs are completely unmet.

- A) True
- B) False

Answer: B – False

Explanation: Maslow emphasized a **hierarchy**, where lower-level needs (physiological, safety) must be **at least partially satisfied** before higher needs motivate behavior.

Q16 (Situational): A social reformer continues to fight for justice despite hunger, illness, and harassment. According to Maslow, which concept explains this behavior?

- A) Safety needs
- B) Meta-needs
- C) Self-esteem
- D) Belongingness

Answer: B – Meta-needs

Explanation: Meta-needs (justice, goodness) **motivate individuals beyond basic survival needs** and can lead people to take risks for higher values.

Q17: Which of the following is NOT a basic concept of humanistic psychology?

- A) Studying humans as a whole
- B) Emphasis on psychological health
- C) Humans are inherently evil
- D) Human creativity is universal

Answer: C – Humans are inherently evil

Explanation: Humanistic psychology believes humans are **basically good**, and behavior problems come from social/environmental factors.

Q18 (Situational/Conceptual): Zainab is highly creative, enjoys learning for its own sake, values deep relationships, and is independent in thought. She has reached which level according to Maslow?

- A) Love and belongingness

- B) Self-esteem
- C) Self-actualization
- D) Safety

Answer: C – Self-actualization

Explanation: Self-actualizers demonstrate **creativity, independence, meaningful relationships, and personal growth.**

Q19 (Tricky): Which is a characteristic of meta-needs?

- A) They are always hierarchical like basic needs.
- B) They are instinctual and do not follow hierarchy.
- C) They include physiological survival needs.
- D) They are irrelevant to self-actualization.

Answer: B – They are instinctual and do not follow hierarchy

Explanation: Meta-needs (justice, beauty) are natural drives **beyond survival** and can motivate behavior independently of lower needs.

Q20 (Situational/True Understanding): Hamza is a child who is often startled by loud noises and prefers predictable routines. Which need is primarily influencing him according to Maslow?

- A) Self-esteem
- B) Safety
- C) Love and belongingness
- D) Self-actualization

Answer: B – Safety

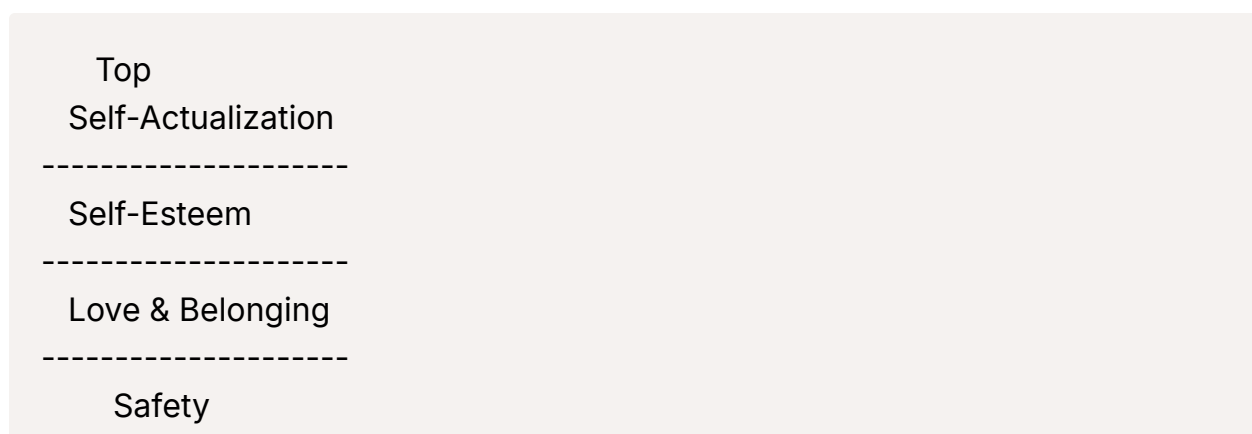
Explanation: Safety needs are about **security, predictability, and protection from harm**, especially important in children due to vulnerability.

Cheat Sheet

1. Key Concepts & Definitions

Term	Definition (Plain English)	Example	Memory Hook
Humanistic Psychology	Focuses on human growth, free choice, positivity, and personal potential	Encouraging a student to take responsibility for learning	"Humans grow, not just survive"
Abnormal Behavior	Unhealthy or unusual behavior	Constant blaming of others for failures	Think: "Avoiding responsibility = abnormal"
Self-Actualization	Reaching your full potential	Artist painting meaningful works	"Be the best YOU"
Meta-Needs	Higher values beyond survival (justice, beauty, goodness, order)	Fighting for social justice despite danger	"Beyond basics = meta"
Physiological Needs	Basic survival needs (food, water, sleep, oxygen)	Eating when hungry	"Body first"
Safety Needs	Desire for security and stability	Having a safe home, job, or routine	"Safety second"
Love/Belonging Needs	Desire for relationships and acceptance	Friendship, family love	"Humans are social"
Self-Esteem Needs	Feeling competent & recognized	Winning a prize, praise from teacher	"Respect yourself & others"

2. Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs (Pyramid)



Physiological
Bottom

Tips:

- Lower needs **must be satisfied first**
- Only a few reach **self-actualization** (<1%)
- Memory trick: **P-S-L-S-S** = Physiological → Safety → Love → Self-esteem → Self-actualization

Example:

- Hungry student → focus on **food**
- Once fed → focus on **friends**
- Later → focus on **achieving personal goals**

3. Maslow's Self-Esteem Division

Type	Description	Example
Self-Respect	Personal competence, confidence, independence	Feeling able to study for exams alone
Esteem from Others	Recognition, appreciation, prestige	Teacher praises student for project

Memory hook: **"Respect self, get respect from others"**

4. Basic vs Meta Needs

Type	Definition	Example
Basic Needs	Survival & social (hunger, safety, love, self-esteem)	Food, shelter, friends, praise
Meta-Needs	Higher values that guide purpose	Justice, beauty, order

Tip: **Basic → satisfy first, Meta → drive higher purpose**

5. Key Features of Humanistic Psychology

Feature	Explanation	Example / Tip
Whole Person	Study humans as integrated, not isolated	Look at full life, not only behavior
Irrelevance of Animals	Humans have self-awareness & creativity	Don't rely on rat experiments for human behavior
Innate Goodness	Humans are basically good	Bad behavior is from environment
Creativity	Everyone has creative potential	Homemakers, teachers, students all can be creative
Psychological Health Focus	Study healthy functioning, not just illness	Observe thriving individuals, not only patients

6. Self-Actualizers – Traits (Simplified)

- Creativity (any field, not just art)
- Independence & autonomy
- Deep meaningful relationships
- Realistic & problem-focused thinking
- Accept self & others
- Sense of humor
- Peak experiences (moments of joy, growth)

Mnemonic: **"C-R-A-D-R-S-P"** → **C**reative, **R**ealistic, **A**ccepts self, **D**eep relations, **R**esponsible, **S**ense of humor, **P**eak moments

7. Situational Tips

- **Think about hierarchy:** If someone lacks food → physiological; if someone is lonely → love/belonging.
- **Meta-needs scenarios:** Justice, beauty, morality → actions beyond survival.

- **Self-actualization clues:** Creativity, independence, purpose-driven.

8. Quick True/False Memory Tips

- Humans are basically **good** → True
- Self-actualization comes **before survival** → False
- Humanistic therapy focuses on **growth**, not illness → True
- Human behavior = **entirely determined by environment** → False

9. Mnemonics & Memory Hooks

1. **Hierarchy of Needs: P-S-L-S-S** → Physiological, Safety, Love, Self-esteem, Self-actualization
2. **Self-esteem types: R-R** → Respect self, Respect from others
3. **Humanistic focus: C-H-I-P** → Creativity, Health, Inner nature, Person as whole
4. **Meta-needs: J-B-G-O** → Justice, Beauty, Goodness, Order

10. Quick Revision Table

Question Type	Answer Tips
Why abnormal behavior happens?	Refusal to accept responsibility + bad environment
Therapy goal?	Growth & self-discovery
Examples of self-actualizers	Artists, scientists, social reformers
Why not everyone self-actualizes?	Fear, lack of awareness, social barriers
Difference: Basic vs Meta needs	Basic = survival; Meta = higher values